

666

**MOURNING BLUFF
MANOR**

at 669 Gallows Way

Core Rules

What you need

One light-backed Tarot deck for each player, one contrasting dark-backed Tarot deck for the GM, a Cast sheet for each player, pencils, and six Grounding tokens per player. Glass beads in a bowl work well. No dice are used.

Tone

Mourning Bluff Manor is exploratory horror, played together by one GM and however many players the table can hold, each one stepping into a different member of the Cast. Ten are written, and any number of them may be at the table on a given night. Nobody here is trying to win a fight: violence happens, but it is rarely the point, and it is never the solution. The real danger is the house itself, its stairs, its locks, its furniture, its memories, its etiquette, its architecture, and its ordinary accidents. There are no monsters waiting in the dark to leap out on cue. What makes Mourning Bluff Manor frightening is that it doesn't need one.

Before play

Each player chooses one member of the Cast. Every character begins with six Grounding tokens.

Prepare each player deck:

1. Separate the 22 Major Arcana from the 56 Minor Arcana.
2. Shuffle the Major Arcana and draw two without looking at them.
3. Shuffle those two cards into the Minor Arcana.
4. Set the remaining Major Arcana aside, face down, out of play. They do not return to this character's deck this session; only the two drawn in step 2 can appear.
5. Place the deck face down and turn its top card face up.

The face-up top card is that character's **Premonition**. Everyone may see it. Whenever it is used or discarded, reveal the next card immediately. Routine actions do not consume cards; a Premonition is discarded only by a test, an ability, a Major effect, or an explicit consequence. Waiting does not make an unwanted future disappear. A character's own Gift or Weakness may change how this works for them specifically, keeping part of their deck hidden, held in reserve, or handled some other way; where a character's file in **cast** / describes something different, follow that instead.

Players may discuss their visible cards and coordinate around them. That is clairvoyance, not cheating. The limitation is fictional: the person taking the risk uses their own future, and a test cannot be transferred to whoever holds the strongest Premonition.

Making a test

Use the visible Premonition, add the relevant Stat, and compare the total with the Difficulty.

Difficulty	When to use
8	Favorable, but failure matters
10	Risky or uncertain
12	Severe danger or opposition
14	Extraordinary circumstances

Results:

- Exceed the Difficulty by 3 or more: the character succeeds cleanly.
- Meet the Difficulty or exceed it by 1 or 2: the character succeeds, but a consequence follows.
- Miss the Difficulty: the action fails and the situation changes for the worse.

Consequences can cost time, separate the group, consume equipment, expose a secret, inflict harm, remove Grounding, attract attention, alter a route, or let the House insert a card. Never repeat the same test without a meaningful change.

A test's Difficulty number may be stated aloud or kept hidden, with only the Stat and the apparent danger named instead. Revealing it keeps the math transparent; withholding it keeps everyone guessing exactly how close a character came.

A test happens only when the outcome is uncertain, failure would change the situation, and the character is exposed to the consequence. A test is never called merely to inspect scenery, open an ordinary drawer, or confirm something the character would already know.

Essential clues are never withheld behind a failed test. A test may determine how safely, quickly, or completely a clue is obtained, or what notices the investigator in return, never whether the core clue exists at all.

Tests follow the character taking the action; the group cannot transfer a test after hearing the required Stat. Once a test's Stat and apparent danger are named, and the Difficulty is either stated or deliberately withheld, the action is committed and cannot be withdrawn.

One action at a time. When several people could act, each is asked what their character is doing before anyone's action resolves. Each character commits to one immediate action.

Weakness: Denial

I cannot believe the supernatural is real; it cannot be real, or I will never sell this godforsaken house.

When you willingly participate in an action whose stated purpose is to communicate with, obey, appease, summon, or banish a supernatural entity, discard your visible Premonition without revealing the next card.

Make your next test blindly. After it resolves, reveal a new Premonition normally.

Gift: Clean Slate

No, I refuse to accept that this is what happens next.

Once per room, before making a test, turn your visible Premonition facedown and shuffle it into your remaining deck. Reveal a new Premonition normally.

Do not shuffle your discard pile. If the newly revealed card is a Major Arcana, it activates normally.

Tool: Skeleton Key

You carry a long iron skeleton key with an oval bow, a narrow shaft, and uneven teeth polished bright from use. A faded paper tag tied to it reads 669 GALLOWS WAY, MOURNING BLUFF, MAINE.

The key was included with the estate papers. It fits many of the manor's original interior locks and may be used in any other way a small metal key reasonably permits.

The key does not automatically open modern locks, combination locks, blocked doors, or locks the house has created or altered.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Inheritor

Bio

You are an ordinary person who has unexpectedly become the legal owner of Mourning Bluff Manor. You have always been more comfortable with training, competition, and physical problems than old documents or ghost stories, and you want nothing to do with the house. Your mother was obsessed with it, but she died when you were very young. After her death, your father destroyed everything she had collected about the manor and refused to speak of it again. Now the estate has passed to you, bringing her obsession back into your life. You have come to understand why she cared about this place and decide what must be done with it.

What Is Established

The manor has legally passed to you. Your mother investigated it before her death, and your father deliberately erased what he could of that connection. You invited or permitted the others to enter because you need answers before you sell, preserve, destroy, or abandon the estate. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Choose the life you built far away from the manor. You might be an athlete, coach, tradesperson, outdoor guide, martial artist, or simply someone who trusts practical action more than old stories. Decide what you remember about your mother, whether you resent or understand your father, and what you hoped the sale of the property would make possible. You may care deeply about the family history, want nothing to do with it, or feel both at once.

Decide Before Play

- What ordinary life did you expect to be living before the manor became yours?
- What is the one memory of your mother that your father could not destroy?
- Which person in the group did you personally ask to come, and why do you trust them?

Stats

Nerve +3 | Notice +1 | Rapport +2 | Reason +0 | Vigor +4

Choosing a Stat

Choose the Stat according to the obstacle the character must overcome and how they confront it, not merely the broad action they are attempting. The same goal can require different Stats when approached differently. Opening a sealed door might use Vigor to force it, Reason to defeat its mechanism, or Notice to find its concealed release. When two Stats honestly apply, the player describes how the character approaches the problem, and the matching Stat and Difficulty follow from that.

Notice

Notice is perception and awareness. It detects something present now but does not explain what that evidence means.

Examples:

1. Spot a tripwire before stepping through a doorway.
2. Hear movement inside a wall before whatever is there emerges.
3. Realize that a portrait's hands have changed position.
4. Catch someone slipping a key into their pocket.
5. Follow a faint trail of blood across a patterned carpet.

Use Reason, not Notice, when the important question is what the discovered evidence means.

Reason

Reason is intelligence, learned knowledge, judgment, and willpower. It interprets evidence, applies expertise, solves problems, and resists attempts to override the character's conscious mind.

Examples:

1. Reconstruct the order of events from marks left in a disturbed room.
2. Stabilize a badly bleeding wound with limited supplies before the patient goes into shock.
3. Recognize the contradiction in a supernatural command and reject it as an intrusion.
4. Work out how to stop a clockwork lock without triggering it.
5. Identify the historical purpose of a symbol carved into a lintel.

Use Notice, not Reason, when the challenge is finding or sensing the evidence in the first place.

Rapport

Rapport is charisma and social influence. It covers persuasion, empathy, reassurance, deception, intimidation, bargaining, and reading another person's emotional intent.

Examples:

1. Calm a panicking companion enough for them to follow instructions.
2. Persuade a hostile apparition to answer one question.
3. Convince a suspicious stranger that you belong in the house.
4. Recognize what subject a grieving spirit is refusing to discuss.
5. Negotiate terms with an entity offering safe passage.

Rapport influences another will. Reason or Nerve resists it, depending on how the character holds their ground.

Nerve

Nerve is stamina, pain tolerance, courage, and sanity. It governs how long the character can endure physical or psychological strain without breaking down.

Examples:

1. Cross a nursery while something unseen whispers your name.
2. Keep moving after hours without sleep or safe rest.
3. Keep treating an injury while a corpse speaks beside you.
4. Remain functional through severe pain until immediate danger passes.
5. Resist a supernatural command through courage and raw refusal to break.

A mental command may use Reason if the character exposes its falsehood, or Nerve if they endure its pressure through sheer grit.

Tool: Incomplete Map

You carry a roughly drawn map made by an inexperienced hand with colored markers on several sheets of paper taped together. The lines are uneven, labels crowd one another, and the whole thing has been folded and unfolded until the paper has softened and the tape has begun to split along the creases.

You may consult it, annotate it, compare it with the house, show it to others, or use the physical map in any other reasonable way. When examining a visible exit, you may ask the GM where the map claims it should lead. The GM answers according to the map.

The map may be outdated, incomplete, or wrong, but it always gives a specific destination rather than no information at all.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

Weakness: Dream Logic

I learned the house's rules in my dreams. Breaking them now feels like stepping off a path in the dark.

When you enter a room, the GM may tell you one simple rule you remember from your dreams.

If you knowingly break that rule, shuffle the cards remaining in your hand and place them facedown. For the rest of the room, choose cards from your hand blindly. If you exhaust the hand before the room ends, draw the next hand facedown as well.

When the room ends, you may look at the cards remaining in your hand again.

Gift: Possible Futures

Every choice has already happened somewhere. I can still choose the version I want.

Draw five cards and keep them in a private hand. You do not have a visible Premonition between tests. When making a test, choose one card from your hand and reveal it.

Do not draw replacement cards individually. Only after every card in your hand has been played or discarded do you draw a new hand of five.

A Major Arcana remains dormant while it is in your hand. If you reveal one for a test, it activates before the test. After resolving it, set it aside and choose another card for the interrupted test.

A dark House card also remains dormant in your hand. It cannot be discarded voluntarily, and you must play it before drawing a new hand. When the House inserts a card into your deck, place it directly into your current hand without counting it toward your five cards. If you are Unmoored, the inserted House card becomes the next card you play.

If another character's ability refers to your visible Premonition, it may affect the card you have chosen after you reveal it. The Relative may exchange Premonitions with you at that point, and the Priest may prevent a Major Arcana you reveal from activating. When you Help with a test, choose and reveal a card from your hand as your committed card.

If you become Unmoored, shuffle your current hand and place it facedown. Choose cards from it blindly, and draw future hands facedown, until you recover Grounding.

Vigor

Vigor is strength, dexterity, agility, coordination, and athletics. It governs active physical performance rather than the stamina to endure prolonged strain.

Examples:

- 1. Force open a swollen wooden door before the corridor closes.
- 2. Climb a crumbling exterior wall in heavy rain.
- 3. Leap across a gap where the staircase has vanished.
- 4. Carry an injured companion away from a collapsing ceiling.
- 5. Pick a simple lock with improvised tools before approaching footsteps arrive.

Vigor handles active physical performance. Nerve handles prolonged exertion, pain, fear, and exhaustion.

Each Cast member has +4, +3, +2, +1, and +0 assigned once each across the five Stats (see **cast** / for exact assignments). The Stat measures capability; the card represents the future already waiting for them.

Reading the Minor Arcana

Card	Test value	Additional effect
Ace	Critical success	Regain 1 Grounding
2-10	Printed value	None
Page	11	None
Knight	12	None
Queen	Automatic success	Lose 1 Grounding
King	Critical failure	Lose 1 Grounding

An Ace succeeds cleanly regardless of Stat or Difficulty, no consequence, and returns one Grounding bead to the character, up to their starting maximum.

A Queen also succeeds cleanly regardless of Stat or Difficulty, no consequence, but the vision costs something vital: move one Grounding bead into the pool after resolving the action.

A King fails automatically, regardless of Stat or Difficulty. The action fails and the situation changes for the worse, exactly as with any missed test, and the character also moves one Grounding bead into the pool: an omen turning against them.

The Four Suits

The suits are known to the players. They do not change the number or add a bonus. They tell everyone what kind of future surrounds the action and shape the benefits and consequences that follow. A suit is permission, not a command; its influence can be subtle, and players should gradually recognize the house's recurring symbolic vocabulary.

- **Cups, emotion and memory.** Relationships, grief, desire, empathy, family, spirits, dreams, and recollection.
- **Pentacles, the material house.** Objects, evidence, money, bargains, possessions, architecture, doors, and physical traces.
- **Swords, danger and truth.** Fear, conflict, pain, separation, difficult knowledge, accusation, and decisive harm.
- **Wands, action and change.** Instinct, movement, ambition, transformation, fire, supernatural power, and things set in motion.

Major Arcana: House Layers

A Major Arcana is never used as a test value. The instant one becomes the active card, through revealing, an ability, or a House card, stop play and announce it.

An immediate change affects the whole house and establishes the card's ongoing Layer. Then every character's Premonition resets before play resumes: the character who revealed the Major discards it and reveals their next card; every other character discards their current Premonition without using it and reveals a new one. If another Major appears during the reset, everyone finishes resetting first, then that Major resolves normally.

Merely seeing a deeper Major through an ability does not activate it. It activates only when it reaches the top or is drawn for use.

A Layer usually lasts until another Major replaces it or until its fiction is resolved. It creates both danger and opportunity; unavoidable harm never lands without giving the players something meaningful to do.

Repeated cards. If a Major appears again, intensify or transform its earlier meaning. The house remembers. A second Hermit might extinguish even personal lights; a second Lovers might bind enemies rather than friends; a second World might close every route except one.

The Dreamer

Bio

You have walked the rooms of Mourning Bluff Manor in your dreams for months, recognizing people you have never met and always waking before you reach the same locked door. Recently the dreams changed: a group of visitors entered the house together, and one of them was you. When you discovered that an investigation was actually being organized, you contacted the others because you already knew where and when they would meet.

What Is Established

The dreams began before you knew the manor or the investigation existed. They contain real details, but they are incomplete and may not obey waking logic. You chose to follow the dream into the house rather than wait for it to come true without you. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Your waking life is yours to define. You could be artistic, methodical, spiritual, skeptical, exhausted, or entirely ordinary. Decide whether you record the dreams, hide them, turn them into art, or treat them as a medical problem. You may believe the dreams are prophecy, trauma, coincidence, or a message from something inside the house. You do not have to decide which explanation is true.

Decide Before Play

- What changed in your life when the dreams began?
- What harmless detail from the manor have you seen so often that it feels like home?
- What do you believe waits behind the locked door?

Stats

Nerve +3 | Notice +4 | Rapport +2 | Reason +1 | Vigor +0

Tool: Crucifix

You carry a small silver crucifix on a black cord, its edges worn smooth from years of being held during prayer.

It has accompanied you throughout your ministry. It may be held, displayed, placed upon a threshold, incorporated into a rite, offered to someone in need, or used in any other way the object and your faith reasonably permit.

Spirits may recognize, respect, fear, resent, or ignore it according to what they are and what the symbol means to them. The crucifix offers no automatic protection merely because it is present.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

Major Arcana I

- **The Fool.** Continuity is abandoned. Thresholds lead somewhere unexpected and new paths appear.
- **The Magician.** Tools and objects activate or perform impossible functions. Solutions demand deliberate use.
- **The High Priestess.** Silence and secrecy descend. Hidden things are easier to notice; speaking a truth may erase it.
- **The Empress.** Growth and hospitality become possessive. Roots spread, food freshens, and the house tries to nurture what it claims.
- **The Emperor.** Architecture imposes order. Doors lock, rooms acquire labels, and rank or rules suddenly matter.
- **The Hierophant.** Old customs resume. Etiquette, ritual, and household roles can protect those who obey them.

Major Arcana II

- **The Lovers.** Bonds become literal. Paired people share sensations, choices, locations, or consequences.
- **The Chariot.** The house moves. Corridors travel, staircases change direction, and entire rooms shift position.
- **Strength.** Restrained things test their bonds. Force worsens the danger; patience or compassion creates leverage.
- **The Hermit.** Isolation and darkness spread. Personal lights reveal things the house ordinarily hides.
- **Wheel of Fortune.** Rooms and consequences repeat in altered form. Something lost may return, but never unchanged.

Major Arcana III

- **Justice.** The house balances a debt with ancient, exacting fairness.
- **The Hanged Man.** Gravity or perspective overturns. Progress requires surrendering the obvious route.
- **Death.** Something ends and transforms. Death is not automatically physical or final.
- **Temperance.** Boundaries blend: rooms, times, people, and states of life overlap.
- **The Devil.** The house makes a tempting offer. Acceptance creates a bond or obligation.
- **The Tower.** Violent restructuring exposes what was concealed as routes and certainties collapse.

Major Arcana IV

- **The Star.** Genuine clarity arrives. For a moment, the house cannot completely falsify what is learned.
- **The Moon.** Perception, geography, and identity become unreliable, but every falsehood contains a contradiction.
- **The Sun.** Merciless exposure reveals hidden things, including truths the characters hoped to keep private.
- **Judgement.** The living and dead are called to account through confession, accusation, or request.
- **The World.** The house briefly aligns into a comprehensible whole. A route toward the center or exit appears as side paths close.

Helping and acting together

One character leads a test. A second character may help only by describing a concrete action that could change the outcome. The helper does not commit or reveal a card: add the helper's relevant Stat directly to the lead character's total for that test.

Helping does not cost the helper anything, no card, no consequence, no Grounding. What limits it is the fiction: the help only counts if the described action could plausibly change the outcome, and only one character may lead a given test.

Group dangers. When an event threatens everyone, do not ask one character to solve it for the table. Each endangered character tests the appropriate Stat, but their circumstances may differ: one holds the door, another guides someone through the dark, another resists the voice calling from upstairs.

The Priest

Bio

You have spent years listening to people describe grief, guilt, visions, and experiences they believe were supernatural. Most needed compassion more than an exorcism. When the new inheritor sought help concerning Mourning Bluff Manor, you agreed to enter, investigate its stories, and determine whether the house requires a blessing, a more serious spiritual intervention, or no religious response at all. You are here to protect the living before passing judgment on the dead.

Stats

Nerve +0 | Notice +2 | Rapport +4 | Reason +3 | Vigor +1

Weakness: Beyond Doctrine

I know God's creation has an order; whatever is in this house must obey it.

When you confront a supernatural phenomenon with prayer, scripture, the crucifix, or a religious rite, the GM tells you whether it recognizes what you are doing.

If it does not recognize or respond to the act, take -3 on your next test involving that phenomenon.

The penalty ends after that test, regardless of its result.

Gift: Sacrifice the Crucifix

Faith is not the object in my hand; it is what I am willing to surrender.

Once per game, when any character reveals a Major Arcana, you may expend your crucifix to prevent that Major from activating.

Remove the Major from the deck and set it aside for the remainder of the game. The crucifix is destroyed, broken, or rendered spiritually powerless and can no longer be used as a Tool.

Weakness: Tunnel Vision

They removed me from the case because I could not let it go, and I still cannot leave a question unanswered.

When you fail a Notice test, you refuse to willingly leave the room until you succeed at another test of any kind.

If you are forced to leave before succeeding, discard your visible Premonition without revealing the next card. Continue making tests blindly until you succeed at a test. After that success resolves, reveal a new Premonition normally.

A success with a consequence counts as succeeding.

Gift: Follow a Lead

There is always another lead; I only have to choose the right one.

Once per room, when you would reveal a new Premonition, reveal the top two cards of your deck instead.

Choose one to become your new Premonition and place the other on the bottom of your deck.

Only the chosen card becomes active. If it is a Major Arcana, resolve it immediately. A Major placed on the bottom does not activate.

Tool: Flashlight

You carry a heavy black metal flashlight with a wide glass lens, a ridged grip, and a sliding switch worn smooth by years of use. Its casing is scratched and dented, but its strong white beam still cuts cleanly through the dark.

While it is working and pointed toward something, its beam illuminates ordinary darkness. You may carry it, hand it to someone, set it down, signal with it, or use it as the durable handheld object that it is.

Its light does not automatically reveal anything concealed by walls, fog, supernatural darkness, or an effect that prevents something from being perceived.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The House Deck

The GM keeps a complete dark-backed Tarot deck as the House Deck. Its cards may be inserted into player decks when the house gains influence. Because the backs differ, a player can see the contamination approaching without knowing its face.

How close. Insertion distance is tied to the target's current Grounding. At 5-6 Grounding, insert within the next six cards. At 3-4, within the next four. At 1-2, within the next two. At 0, place it directly beneath the active card. Do not count exact positions aloud.

When revealed. A dark Minor Arcana still resolves at its normal value and retains any Ace, Queen, or King rule. In addition, an intrusion follows based on its suit: Cups disturb memory or feeling; Pentacles alter an object or route; Swords bring threat or painful truth; Wands set an unnatural change in motion. After resolution, a dark card returns to the House Deck's discard pile rather than the player's discard pile.

Dark Major Arcana. A dark Major creates a House Layer like any other Major, but it is targeted at the character whose deck carried it. It may expose their Weakness, imitate an established personal detail, or reshape a room around something they brought into the house.

Grounding

Grounding measures a character's ability to distinguish themselves from the house and the future pressing upon them. Each character begins with six counters. Keep them visible near the character sheet.

Losing Grounding. Move a counter into the central pool when a Queen is used, when a rule specifically requires it, or when Grounding loss is offered as a consequence appropriate to psychic strain, isolation, possession, or surrendering part of oneself.

Regaining Grounding. An Ace returns one of that character's counters from the pool, up to six. Certain discoveries, honest connections, safe rooms, or a meaningful personal turning point may also restore Grounding, when the moment genuinely calls for it.

At zero: Unmoored. An Unmoored character remains playable, but the boundary between character and house has opened. Turn their visible Premonition face down; they must now draw tests blindly. Whenever they fail a test or use a Queen, a House card may be inserted directly beneath the top card instead of removing another Grounding.

An Unmoored character can recover only by an Ace, or by accepting meaningful help in a place of safety.

Physical harm

Physical harm is described specifically rather than tracked with points or boxes. A character might suffer a sprained ankle, a bleeding hand, a concussion, or broken ribs. The injury affects only actions it would reasonably hinder or prevent.

Failing a Vigor test does not automatically cause physical harm. The consequence follows the danger established before the test. Failing to lift a fallen beam may simply leave it blocking the way; failing to jump across a hole may cause a fall and an injury.

Another test happens only when an injury makes a later action dangerous or uncertain. Appropriate medical attention changes what the injury prevents or how it may worsen. Providing ordinary care does not require a test unless pressure, inadequate supplies, an unusual injury, or another meaningful uncertainty makes failure consequential.

Tools

A Tool can be used in any way the physical object reasonably permits. Its description establishes what the character carries and any unusual qualities it possesses; it does not limit the Tool to one listed action. Using a Tool does not require a test when it makes the outcome safe and certain. A test happens only when meaningful danger or uncertainty remains.

The Detective

Bio

You spent years investigating disappearances connected to Mourning Bluff Manor. What began as an overlooked pattern became the only case that mattered to you. Your superiors called your conclusions speculative, then reckless, and finally removed you from the investigation. You are officially on administrative leave and have been ordered to stay away. You have entered the manor anyway, determined to find the evidence that proves the disappearances are connected, and that you were right to keep digging.

What Is Established

You found a credible pattern linking multiple disappearances to the manor, but you could not prove the connection through official channels. Your investigation cost you professionally, and entering the property violates direct instructions. You still believe the missing deserve an answer. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Choose the agency, jurisdiction, and kind of investigative work you did. Decide whether you were once careful and respected, always difficult, or made one catastrophic judgment call. Your investment may be professional, personal, moral, or all three. Define one victim whose case you cannot set aside and the investigative habit your colleagues found impossible to tolerate.

Decide Before Play

- Which disappearance transformed the manor from a theory into an obsession?
- What evidence did your superiors dismiss?
- Who in the group reminds you of someone you failed to protect?

Stats

Nerve +1 | Notice +4 | Rapport +0 | Reason +3 | Vigor +2

Tool: Microcassette Recorder

You carry a palm-sized microcassette recorder with a scratched plastic casing, a built-in speaker, and large mechanical buttons that click loudly when pressed. The cassette inside contains recordings of your final sessions with the patient, and the carrying case holds several blank tapes and spare batteries.

The recordings preserve the patient's actual voice as they describe memories, dreams, fears, and contradictory experiences inside Mourning Bluff Manor. You may rewind, replay, pause, compare sessions with the house, let others listen, or refer back to anything the patient said.

The sessions are fixed, but the patient may have been mistaken, confused, deceptive, or accurate in ways that were impossible to recognize outside the manor. The recorder can also make new recordings and may be used in any other way the physical device reasonably permits.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Historical Archaeologist

Bio

Someone anonymously sent you a box containing photographs, floor plans, correspondence, and property records from Mourning Bluff Manor that have never appeared in any archive. The documents establish that a previously unknown inheritor now owns the estate. The inheritor asked you to investigate the property and prove that its infamous hauntings are tricks, misunderstandings, or stories grown wild with age.

What Is Established

The anonymous archive is genuine enough to demand investigation, but you do not know who assembled or sent it. The Inheritor brought you in for your professional judgment. You regard the manor as a historical site whose physical evidence can be permanently lost through careless handling. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Choose your specialty: historic architecture, material culture, funerary practice, industrial archaeology, photographic history, local history, conservation, or something equally relevant. You may work for a university, museum, preservation office, private firm, or yourself. Decide whether this discovery could restore your reputation, define your career, answer a private question, or expose an institution that ignored the site.

Decide Before Play

- What item in the anonymous box convinced you it was not an ordinary hoax?
- What professional mistake or triumph shaped your approach to fragile evidence?
- What part of the manor's history do you most hope to recover intact?

Stats

Nerve +2 | Notice +4 | Rapport +1 | Reason +3 | Vigor +0

Weakness: Leave It Intact

This manor is a historical site, and if I destroy any part of it, I could erase the truth I came to uncover.

When you deliberately damage or destroy part of Mourning Bluff Manor or one of its contents, discard your visible Premonition without revealing the next card.

Make your next test blindly. After it resolves, reveal a new Premonition normally.

Gift: Follow the Evidence

The answer is already here; I only need to look closely enough.

Before making a Reason test to research documents or analyze physical evidence, look at the card directly beneath your Premonition. You may exchange the two cards.

If exchanged, the lower card becomes your new Premonition and the previous Premonition goes directly beneath it.

Tool: Field Notebook

The notebook contains your written observations, measurements, sketches, rubbings, and loose research materials. You may add to it, consult it, show it to others, remove pages, or use it in any other way a physical notebook reasonably permits.

When you enter a room, you may carefully document one specific item or physical detail. Once recorded, that item or detail cannot change for as long as the entry remains intact in your notebook.

The house may change everything around it, but the recorded detail remains exactly as you described it. The entry must describe something concrete and observable, not a conclusion. You could preserve the position of a chair, the wording of a sign, the dimensions of a doorway, or the appearance of a portrait. You could not write that a room is safe or that a door leads outside.

If the relevant page is removed or destroyed, the detail is no longer protected.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Psychiatrist

Bio

You were the attending psychiatrist responsible for the last known person to enter Mourning Bluff Manor. They returned alive but profoundly disturbed, unable to separate memories from hallucinations or describe the house without contradicting themselves. Nothing you tried restored them, and their condition has continued to deteriorate. You have entered the manor to understand what happened to your patient and determine whether the source was trauma, delusion, or something you were never trained to diagnose.

Stats

Nerve +1 | Notice +0 | Rapport +4 | Reason +3 | Vigor +2

Weakness: Fear of Isolation

I could not bring my patient back from what they experienced, and I cannot face this house without another living person nearby.

Whenever you fail a test while alone, lose 1 Grounding.

You are alone when no other player character is present in the same room. Spirits, apparitions, and other inhabitants of the house do not count.

Gift: Reframe

I cannot change an experience, but I can change the meaning it carries.

Once per room, before making a test, you may change the suit of your visible Minor Arcana.

Its value remains unchanged. Treat it as the chosen suit for that test and for any effect that refers to its suit. After the test, it returns to its printed suit before being discarded.

Weakness: No Baseline

I trust observation over instinct, and I need to see someone else's response before I commit myself.

If you make the first test in a room, discard your visible Premonition without revealing the next card and make that test blindly.

After the test resolves, reveal a new Premonition normally.

Gift: Expected Value

I do not need certainty; I only need the most likely outcome.

Once per room, before making a test, you may use a test value of 8 instead of using your Premonition. Add the relevant Stat normally.

This result has no suit or special card effect. Your Premonition remains visible and in place.

Tool: Environmental Data Logger

You carry a rugged black data logger about the size of a paperback book, with rubberized corners, a small green display, several blinking indicator lights, and a bundle of wired sensors clipped to its case. Its internal clock continuously records and timestamps temperature, air pressure, vibration, sound, and electromagnetic activity.

When something apparently supernatural happens, you may examine the logger. The GM tells you which measurements changed and which remained physically normal. The logger records physical conditions, not their cause, and a phenomenon may leave no measurable trace.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Relative

Bio

Someone you love became obsessed with Mourning Bluff Manor and disappeared while trying to reach it. The authorities found no evidence that they ever entered the estate. When you learned that the new inheritor was allowing a private investigation, you demanded a place in the group. You are not interested in ghost stories. You want to discover what happened and, against all reason, still hope to bring them home.

Stats

Nerve +4 | Notice +2 | Rapport +3 | Reason +0 | Vigor +1

Weakness: Survivor's Guilt

I already lost someone to this house, and I cannot bear to let it happen again.

If a member of the group goes missing, discard your visible Premonition without revealing the next card. A character is missing when their location is unknown or the house has cut them off from the group, not merely because they willingly entered a nearby room.

Until you are reunited with the missing character, make every test using the top card of your deck without looking at it. After each test, discard the card used but do not reveal the next one. If several characters are missing, your Premonition remains hidden until everyone who is still missing has returned.

When you are reunited, turn the top card of your deck faceup. It becomes your visible Premonition normally.

Gift: Take My Future

If someone has to face what is coming, let it be me.

Once per room, when another character is about to make a test, you may exchange your visible Premonition with theirs. They make the test using your former card; their former card becomes your Premonition.

You cannot use this Gift while Survivor's Guilt has left your Premonition hidden.

Tool: Family Photograph

You carry a slightly faded Polaroid of the missing person laughing in a sunlit park. They are caught mid-laugh with their head turned slightly away from the camera, one hand raised as if they had just tried to hide their face. Green grass, a picnic table, and several distant trees fill the background. It was taken before they became obsessed with Mourning Bluff Manor.

The photograph may change in response to the group's actions. When you examine it, ask the GM what it currently shows. The GM describes one subtle difference or tells you that it remains unchanged. Changes might affect the missing person's expression, surroundings, clothing, position, or something previously unnoticed in the background.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Psychic Researcher

Bio

You study clairvoyance, precognition, and anomalous perception through controlled experiments. You want psychic phenomena to be real, but every case you have examined has collapsed under scrutiny, produced inconclusive results, or could not be repeated. When invited to join the investigation of Mourning Bluff Manor, you accepted the opportunity to observe a reputed haunting firsthand. You are not there to communicate with the dead or explain away what happens. You want to determine whether genuine psychic phenomena can be measured, repeated, and quantified.

What Is Established

You approach anomalous experiences as evidence rather than revelation. You are not here merely to debunk the haunting or commune with it; you want results that can be recorded, compared, and repeated. Your equipment and expertise are real even if your field is treated with suspicion. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Choose the discipline that brought you here: psychology, neuroscience, statistics, parapsychology, anthropology, engineering, or independent research. Decide who funds your work, what professional failure still follows you, and whether you secretly need the house to prove you right. You may be warm with subjects, clinically distant, or trying to become better at seeing the people behind the data.

Decide Before Play

- What previous experiment came closest to convincing you?
- Who would take your findings seriously if you returned with proof?
- Which person here are you most tempted to treat as a research subject?

Stats

Nerve +3 | Notice +2 | Rapport +1 | Reason +4 | Vigor +0

Weakness: Do No Harm

When someone is hurt, I have one job. If I fail at it, I start expecting the worst.

When you fail a test made to provide medical aid to someone who has suffered physical harm, look at the top three cards of your deck instead of revealing your next Premonition.

Place the lowest-valued card on top of your deck faceup as your new Premonition. Put the other two on the bottom of your deck in any order. If cards are tied for the lowest value, choose between them. For this Weakness, a Major Arcana is lower than any Minor Arcana; if it becomes your Premonition, it activates normally.

Gift: In Reserve

I prepare because preparation is what keeps an emergency from becoming a tragedy.

Once per room, you may set your visible Premonition aside faceup without playing or discarding it, then reveal your next Premonition normally.

You may use the reserved card for a later test instead of your current Premonition. Afterward, discard the reserved card; your current Premonition remains in place.

You can hold only one card in reserve. A Major cannot be placed in reserve because it activates as soon as it reaches the top of your deck.

Tool: Medical Bag

You carry a compact red trauma bag made from heavy waterproof fabric, with reflective strips, reinforced handles, and several zippered compartments. Inside are gloves, gauze, bandages, medical tape, antiseptic, trauma shears, a tourniquet, instant cold packs, a folding splint, a stethoscope, a penlight, and a small supply of common emergency medications.

You can use these supplies to stop bleeding, clean and dress wounds, support an injured limb, manage shock, administer appropriate medication, or provide other medical aid. The bag and everything inside it may also be used in any other way the physical objects reasonably permit.

The bag cannot restore Grounding or cure possession, supernatural transformation, or other conditions that are not ordinary physical harm.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Fraudulent Medium

Bio

You make a living pretending to speak with the dead. Outwardly, you perform with absolute confidence; privately, you believe you are a fraud who has mistaken instinct and coincidence for something more. But once, and only once, you had a vision you could not explain. You saw Mourning Bluff Manor, including details you later confirmed had never been made public. You have come to the house grasping for proof that the vision was real and that perhaps you have not been pretending all this time.

What Is Established

Your public career depends on presenting uncertainty as supernatural certainty. Most of your work uses performance, observation, research, and cold reading. The vision of the manor was different, and no explanation you have tried has accounted for it. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Create your stage persona and decide how famous, successful, or desperate you are. You might be a theatrical entertainer, a private grief counselor with questionable methods, a television personality, a social-media psychic, or a small-time reader working fairs and parlors. Decide whether you feel guilty about the comfort you sell, proud that it helps people, or terrified that a genuine gift would make every lie unforgivable.

Decide Before Play

- What detail from the vision could you never have learned normally?
- What performance technique do you rely on when you feel cornered?
- Who have you genuinely helped despite the deception?

Stats

Nerve +2 | Notice +3 | Rapport +4 | Reason +1 | Vigor +0

Weakness: Never Break Character

If I admit uncertainty, everyone will see me for the fraud I really am.

If you openly admit that you may be a fraud, retract a supernatural claim, or confess that you do not know what your vision means, put the three visible cards on the bottom of your deck in any order. Then draw three new cards and keep them facedown.

Play those cards blindly from the top of your deck. Until all three have been played, they remain facedown. Then reveal the next three cards and resume using The Sight normally.

Gift: The Sight

I saw this house before I knew it existed; that has to mean something.

Keep the top three cards of your deck faceup in order. Everyone may see them, but only the topmost card is your active Premonition and only that card may be played or discarded.

Whenever the active card leaves your deck, the second card becomes active and you reveal another card so that three are visible again.

Seeing a Major among the three cards does not activate it. It activates only when it reaches the top.

Tool: Séance Bell

You carry a small brass séance bell with a dark wooden handle worn smooth by years of use. Bells like this are traditionally placed on séance tables so spirits can announce their presence or answer questions by ringing without a living hand touching them.

Place the bell on a stable surface, ask a yes-or-no question aloud, and ring it once.

If a spirit in the room chooses to answer, the bell rings once for yes or twice for no without being touched. Silence means that no answer was given. The response comes from the spirit, not the GM, and the spirit may lie, misunderstand the question, or have incomplete knowledge.

Secret

Create a Secret that your character must hide from the rest of the group. It should be something that could cause conflict if the others discovered it.

The Paramedic

Bio

One of the people entering Mourning Bluff Manor is your friend, and you insisted on coming because someone needed to take the ordinary dangers seriously. You do not necessarily believe the house is haunted, but you do believe in rotten floorboards, rusty nails, asbestos, unstable stairs, and being hours away from medical help. Once people start getting hurt, it does not matter who brought you here. You are the person with the training to keep them alive.

What Is Established

Choose one of the other selected characters as your friend. You came partly because of them and will not casually abandon them. You are trained to provide emergency medical aid, but the manor can create injuries and conditions that do not behave like ordinary harm. Your name, age, gender, appearance, occupation, relationships, and personal history are yours unless established above.

Make the Character Your Own

Your concern for your friend does not have to be your only reason for coming. You might follow true-crime cases, explore abandoned places, collect local folklore, have family ties to the area, or simply distrust the plan enough to supervise it yourself. Decide where you work, what kind of emergencies shaped you, and whether your competence makes you calm, controlling, compassionate, or all three.

Decide Before Play

- Which character is your friend, and what have the two of you already survived together?
- What personal interest in the manor are you reluctant to admit?
- What kind of emergency still makes it difficult for you to stay objective?

Stats

Nerve +3 | Notice +1 | Rapport +0 | Reason +2 | Vigor +4